

Basic U.S. Economic Conditions Tracker

A Five-Report Guide to Understanding the U.S. Economy

About This Workbook

The Basic U.S. Economic Conditions Tracker is designed for those who want a practical way to follow major U.S. economic reports without needing a background in economics.

What this workbook does

- Directs you to official U.S. government economic releases
- Identifies the specific tables, sections, and values used in each worksheet
- Compares current and previous periods in a consistent format
- Introduces the basic differences between growth, spending, inflation, and employment data
- Creates a repeatable process you can use each time a new report is released

The five reports

Report	What it helps you observe
Gross Domestic Product (GDP)	Overall economic growth
Personal Income & Outlays	Broad consumer spending, income, and saving
Retail Sales	Recent retail spending
Consumer Price Index (CPI)	Consumer inflation
Employment Situation	Jobs, unemployment, participation, and wages

What this workbook is not

It is not an economic forecast, investment recommendation, or substitute for the current official release. The purpose is to help you locate, record, and understand reported economic data.

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How to use it:

- 1. Open the official release:** Use the current BEA, Census, or BLS release listed below.
- 2. Go only to the specified section or table:** Do not estimate from charts when an exact published value is available.
- 3. Fill in current and previous values:** Keep units straight: percent, percentage points, dollars, or jobs.

Report Locations:

GDP	https://www.bea.gov/data/gdp/gross-domestic-product	Click “Current Release”
Personal Income & Outlays	https://bea.gov/data/income-saving/personal-income	Click “Current Release”
Retail Sales	https://www.census.gov/retail/sales.html	
Consumer Price Index (CPI)	https://www.bls.gov/	Economic Releases – Inflation & Prices
Employment Situation	https://www.bls.gov/	Economic Releases – Employment & Unemployment - Monthly

Interpretation rules:

- Use reported values, not visual estimates.
- Distinguish growth rates from contributions. A large growth rate does not automatically mean the largest contribution.
- Keep nominal and real measures separate.
- Keep month-over-month and year-over-year measures separate.
- Remember that imports are subtracted in GDP: rising imports can reduce GDP growth.
- Do not infer causation unless the release supports it. State uncertain explanations as inference, not fact.
- When combining reports, state their periods. GDP is quarterly; the other reports may be one or more months newer.

Gross Domestic Product

Quarterly

Source locations:

Webpage text

BEA Table 1.1.1 — Percent Change From Preceding Period in Real Gross Domestic Product

BEA Table 1.5.2 — Contributions to Percent Change in Real GDP, Expanded Detail

Current Quarter: _____ **Previous Quarter:** _____

Table 1.1.1

Item	Current quarter	Previous quarter	Direction
Real GDP	_____ %	_____ %	
C — Personal consumption expenditures	_____ %	_____ %	
I — Gross private domestic investment	_____ %	_____ %	
G — Gov’t consumption expenditures & gross investment	_____ %	_____ %	
X — Exports	_____ %	_____ %	
M — Imports	_____ %	_____ %	

Table 1.5.2

Contribution item	Current quarter
Greatest Positive Contributor	_____ % points
Greatest Negative Contributor	_____ % points

Formula: $GDP = C + I + G + (X - M)$

Conclusion:

Personal Income & Outlays

Monthly

Source Locations:

Webpage text

Scroll down to Personal Income and Related Measures table

Table 2.6

Current Month: _____

Previous Month: _____

Item	Current	Previous	Direction
Current-dollar PCE	_____ %	_____ %	
Real PCE	_____ %	_____ %	
Goods spending change	\$ _____ B	\$ _____ B	
Services spending change	\$ _____ B	\$ _____ B	
Real Disposable Personal Income (DPI)	_____ %	_____ %	
Personal saving rate	_____ %	_____ %	

What does this tell you?

What is driving spending the most? (Goods or Services)

Are people spending? (Current-dollar PCE + Real PCE)

Is household real after-tax income improving? (Real DPI)

Are households saving more or less? (Personal saving rate)

Retail Sales

Monthly

Source Locations:

Webpage text

Scroll down to Advance Monthly Retail Trade Report Tables (use Table 2 in the excel download)

Current Month: _____

Previous Month: _____

Charts / Opening Summary

Item	Current Report
Headline: Month over Month	_____ %
Headline: Year over Year	_____ %
Previous Month: Month over Month	_____ %

Table 2

Retail Sales item	Business Type	Percent Change
Largest category gain MoM		_____ %
Largest category loss MoM		_____ %

Reminder: Retail Sales is not adjusted for price changes, so it is a nominal spending measure.

Conclusion:

Consumer Price Index

Monthly

Source Locations:

Webpage text

Table A

Current Month: _____

Previous Month: _____

Item	Current Month	Previous Month	Direction
Headline CPI — Month over Month	_____ %	_____ %	
Headline CPI — Year over Year	_____ %	_____ %	
Core CPI — Month over Month	_____ %	_____ %	
Core CPI — Year over Year	_____ %	_____ %	
Food — Month over Month	_____ %	_____ %	
Energy — Month over Month	_____ %	_____ %	
Shelter — Month over Month	_____ %	_____ %	

Rate-of-change reminder: A move from -6.0% to -1.0% still means prices fell; the rate of decline simply slowed

Headline inflation: Accelerating Slowing Steady

Core inflation: Accelerating Slowing Steady

Main driver of the monthly headline move: _____

Conclusion:

Employment Situation

Monthly

Source Locations:

Webpage text

Tables: Summary Table A; B-1; B-3

Current Month: _____

Previous Month: _____

Item	Current Month	Previous Month	Direction
Nonfarm payroll change	_____ jobs	_____ jobs	
Unemployment rate	_____ %	_____ %	
Labor force participation rate	_____ %	_____ %	
Average hourly earnings	_____ %	_____ %	
Average hourly earnings — Year over Year	_____ %	_____ %	

Payroll revisions	Amount
Previous month revision	_____ jobs
Two months prior revision	_____ jobs
Combined revision	_____ jobs

Industry Movement	Industry	Jobs
Largest major industry job gain		
Largest major industry job loss		

Conclusion:

Sources, Educational Use & Copyright

Official sources

The economic releases referenced in this workbook are published by the U.S. Bureau of Economic Analysis (BEA), U.S. Census Bureau, and U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS). Users should consult the current official release when completing each worksheet because reported values and prior estimates may be revised.

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